

HUMMINGBIRDS AND SWIFTS

The dashing flight of swifts – fastest of all birds – and the audible hovering of hummingbirds characterize the master aeronauts united in this order.

Both swifts and hummingbirds, members of the order Apodiformes, have tiny feet that are useful only for perching, but in compensation the birds have exceptional manoeuvrability on the wing. Swifts skim through the skies to catch flying insects.

Hummingbirds have the wing control to fly backwards, some of them whirring at over 70 wingbeats per second – sustained by a high metabolism fuelled by energy-rich nectar. Insects and spiders provide hummingbirds with protein to feed to their chicks. Hummingbirds use cobwebs to glue together their thimble-sized nests, while swifts use saliva. The swifts' range is almost worldwide, reaching oceanic islands. Hummingbirds are found only in the Americas.

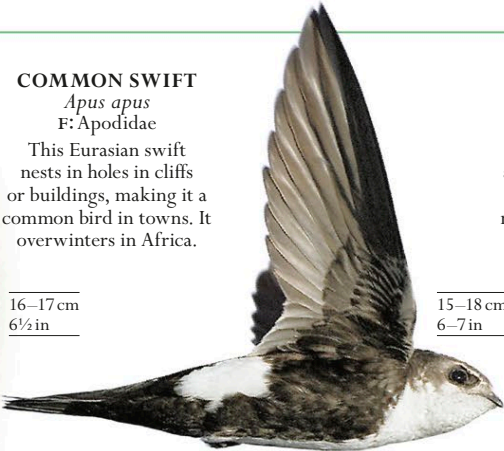
PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	APODIFORMES
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	405



COMMON SWIFT
Apus apus
F: Apodidae

This Eurasian swift nests in holes in cliffs or buildings, making it a common bird in towns. It overwinters in Africa.

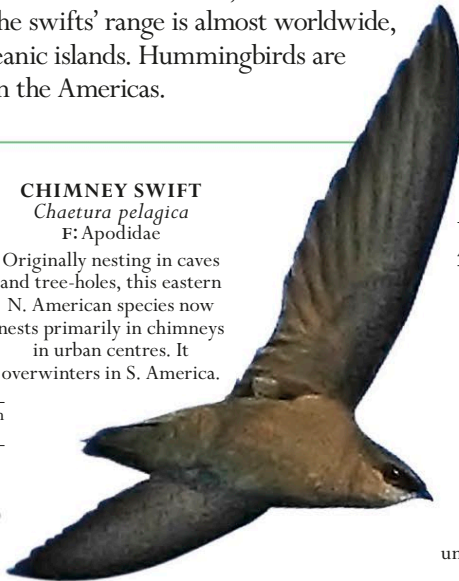
16–17 cm
6½ in



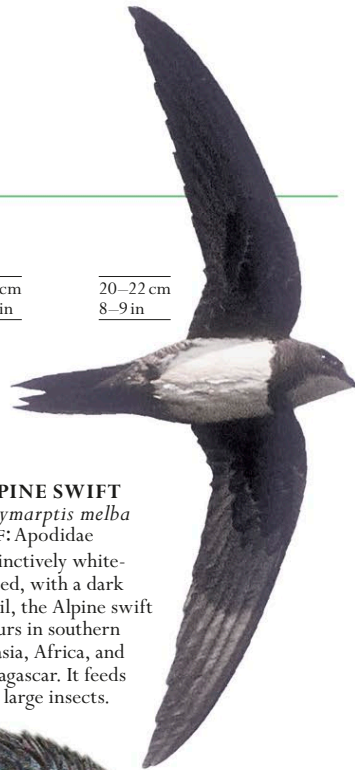
CHIMNEY SWIFT
Chaetura pelagica
F: Apodidae

Originally nesting in caves and tree-holes, this eastern N. American species now nests primarily in chimneys in urban centres. It overwinters in S. America.

15–18 cm
6–7 in



12–15 cm
4¾–6 in



20–22 cm
8–9 in

ALPINE SWIFT
Tachymarptis melba
F: Apodidae

Distinctively white-bellied, with a dark undertail, the Alpine swift occurs in southern Eurasia, Africa, and Madagascar. It feeds on large insects.

WHITE-THROATED SWIFT
Aeronautes saxatalis
F: Apodidae

Found in canyons and mountains of western N. America and C. America, this bird gathers in flocks in the evenings to roost.



WHITE-TIPPED SICKLEBILL
Eutoxeres aquila
F: Trochilidae

This bird has a range that extends from Costa Rica to Peru. It uses its decurved bill to feed from similarly curved *Heliconia* flowers.

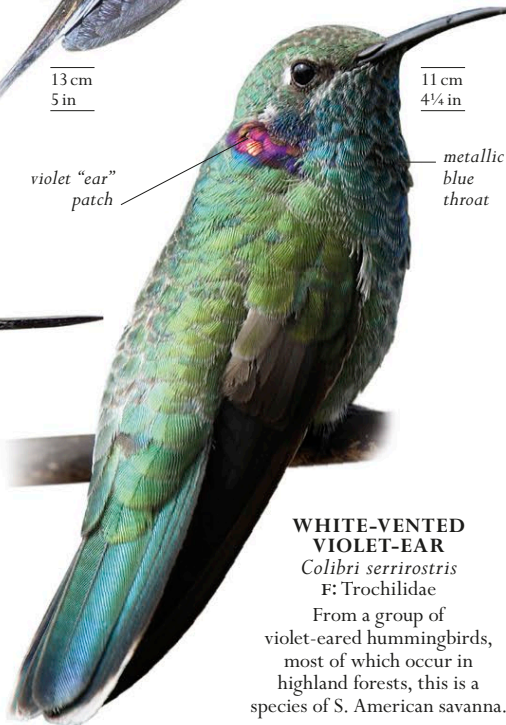


SCALE-THROATED HERMIT
Phaethornis eurynome
F: Trochilidae

Hermits are dull-coloured hummingbirds with a long, curving bill for probing *Heliconia* flowers. This species is from eastern S. America.

13 cm
5 in

violet "ear" patch



WHITE-VENTED VIOLET-EAR
Colibri serrirostris
F: Trochilidae

From a group of violet-eared hummingbirds, most of which occur in highland forests, this is a species of S. American savanna.

11 cm
4¼ in

metallic blue throat



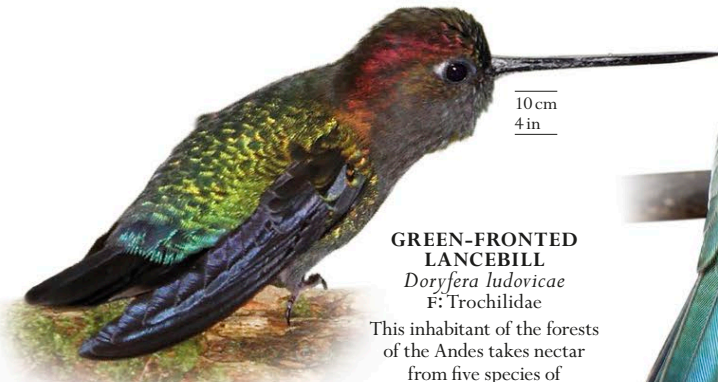
VIOLET SABREWING
Campylopterus hemileucurus
F: Trochilidae

Sabrewings are named for the thickened shafts of their flight feathers. This C. American bird is the largest hummingbird outside S. America.

decurved bill

violet-blue underparts

14–15 cm
5½–6 in



GREEN-FRONTED LANCEBILL
Doryfera ludovicae
F: Trochilidae

This inhabitant of the forests of the Andes takes nectar from five species of epiphytes (plants that grow on other plants), one of which is a mistletoe.

10 cm
4 in

deeply forked tail

12 cm
4¾ in